New York

By David Rimmer

INTRODUCTION

Today all that remains of the World Trade Center is a flight of battered steps, rising into an empty sky. On September 11, hundreds fled down these stairs from the flames and falling debris. "Survivor's guilt" is a term used to describe a sense of self-blame and remorse felt by a person who has experienced or witnessed a life-threatening event during which others did not survive. They begin to question, "Why them and not me?" For most Americans, the moment the airplanes crashed into the World Trade Center is burned into their memories. Collectively, we are all survivors. New York by David Rimmer is just that, a snapshot of survivors. Today I'd like to introduce you to two . . . Mary and Sarah. Mary? (by way of introduction, encouraging her to speak)

MARY: I'm unmarried. I live alone in Brooklyn, behind a Catholic church, which is lucky because it's my church. The Church means a lot to me. The priest, Father Barnes, is my friend. He helped me a lot, but I still thought I'd try you...

(Smiles.)

I'm Director of Human Resources-Personnel-for a research and development company. I've never been married. I was engaged once. Twice. Well... once and a half My mother's gone, my dad's not doing too well. I have two sisters and a brother-younger, married with kids. I guess I was just cut out to be an aunt. Those kids are a joy. I always thought I'd-I never thought I'd look at myself at this age and see someone not married.

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(Shifts in her chair.)

I've been getting panic attacks. The sound of a bang brings it all back. I just-haven't felt the same. On a daily basis. Little things. I get a paper cut every day. Like clockwork. Everything I pick up I drop. I spill-constantly-I'm making my dry cleaners rich.

(Shrugs; sighs.)

It hit me a little harder over the holidays. I was with my family of course. Every time I saw my nieces and nephews run or laugh or have fun, I teared up. They shouldn't have to know about things like - The baby was a comfort though. I looked into her eyes and it was wonderful. She didn't know anything.

(Smiles.)

I have a little garden in the back of my apartment. I go there to-sit, relax, and think. And

(Lightly.)

this is a confession, Father Barnes knows it too. Every month or so, I sit there and have a cigarette. That's all. It's not the world's most shocking confession. The night of Christmas Day I came home, sat outside in my

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big coat, lit a cigarette, and started crying-and I couldn't stop and I burned a hole in my favorite plant. I don't go in my garden any more... All this isn't very important in the big scheme of things.

(Pause)

I feel so self-indulgent! I've never been to a-I don't know why I'm bothering you. I'm sure there're so many people much worse off than me. The young widows - I think of them and - I didn't get on the first subway that morning. It was packed and I thought who needs this? So I waited and took the next subway. I got out of the station at Cortlandt Street and saw a plane go into a building. People were running and I just ran along with them. A vendor had T-shirts and another vendor had bottled water and they were passing them out and people were putting wet T-shirts over

(Covers her mouth and nose.)

Smoke and dust everywhere. A high school ring fell out of the sky right at my feet. Then at that little park near City Hall, my cell phone rang. I didn't want to answer it-I was afraid-I hate cell phones! That stupid little ring! Not like a real phone-People answer them in the middle of the street- "Hello?!"- You think they're yelling at you! - But I answered it. It was Nina Carmichael. She was trapped in a closet in the tower-She went in there to escape the flames and she couldn't get out. She didn't know

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how much time she had-she just knew it wasn't much-She wasn't even a close friend. That's the thing- I barely knew Nina Carmichael-She was in my class at college but I didn't know her that well. She sent me an e-mail over the summer-I was helping her with the class reunion. We had lunch maybe once. I don't know why she called me. She said, "I can't reach my mother, Mary. I love her. I love my father and my sister. Please tell them - " She wanted to pray with me. "I love you Mary- "Then she's gone. I went and told them. They were so - Who am I? Why did she call me? So she wouldn't be.. . alone. . . when she....

TRANSITION

A lot of people talk about how their lives have changed since 9/11 or that their lives have been changed forever. And yet for 97% of people living in the United States the only thing that has really changed is that they pay a little more for gas or they have to wait a bit longer to get on a plane to fly to their favorite vacation spot.

Only those who have experienced sudden tragic loss of a loved one can truly understand the loss of the 9/11 families, and what a struggle each day is when your world is changed forever in an instant.

About 3,000 children lost a parent that day. Sarah, though she'll deny that she had any feelings for her future step-father is one of those children Sarah?

SARAH: So, what.

(Beat)

You want my life story? I live in Queens. My mother's an idiot. She has

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this boyfriend, Dennis. He calls me from this bar the night before 9/11 for no reason. What a dick. No, he-He was just like tryin' too hard to reach out or something. He's marryin' my mom, y'know, so he has to suck up to me. - Hey, I got a dad!

Anyway, Dennis got a week's work in Tower One. He didn't die saving anybody or anything, he was just working maintenance.

I don't know. I guess I liked him all right. Not really. Marie-my mother-she loved him enough for two. It was like, retarded-deranged. I come home, they're all over the couch... "Ohh! Ohh! Ohh!"... They're so stupid. She's pregnant. She's gonna walk down the aisle like this.

(Holds out her stomach, does a mock waddle.)

Nice. Same thing happened when I was born. She was 17. She doesn't learn. They've got this new thing now? Contraception? Hello? And she wanted me to take Dennis' name. I was gonna bail on that one. Now I guess I don't have to...

I was thinkin' of takin' my real dad's name, just to piss her off God, she hates him. She says, "Oh now he comes around, now." What's the difference? I don't miss him - I never knew him. He ditched her and joined the Army when she was gonna have me. I don't blame him. I mighta done it... I see him once in a while. I have to sneak out but-no problem,

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she's clueless.

He's a captain now. I don't think he's a hero or anything, but he looks pretty cool in his uniform. I got no problem with him - he's just a cool guy, no big thing.

Then I met his girlfriend, she's like five years older than me. Why don't these people love people their own age? I don't date twelve-year-olds. Dennis was 28. Marie said he could biologically be my dad. Yeah right, if [they had sex] when he was 11.

So my dad's been in some pretty mellow places so far-you know, Germany, Alaska. Now, I don't know, it might get a little weirder in . . . Afghanistan. So I'm gonna try not gettin' too attached. That's my thing with guys anyway. Never had a boyfriend for more than a day. Marie's different. She can't live without' em.

She cries. . .

(Beat.)

The whole thing's pretty weird, I admit it. The other day I'm in the cafeteria and this girl Lindsay comes up to me and she's like, "What're ya still bummed out for? He wasn't your real dad or anything."

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(Beat.)

I beat the crap out of her.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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